



ZAY-MARIE PRESS

Biblical Interpretation Starter Kit

A practical introduction to reading Scripture with evidence and context

FREE STUDY AND REFERENCE RESOURCE

Where the Bible Means What It Says

Observation • Meaning • Assignment • Application

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Use the sections in order for your first passage study. Afterward, reuse the two-page worksheet and the final review checklist with additional passages.

Welcome

This Starter Kit introduces a disciplined way to study a biblical passage. Its purpose is not to supply conclusions in advance or compress a complete hermeneutics course into a short booklet. It helps you slow down, gather evidence, establish meaning in context, determine proper assignment, and make a legitimate application.

By completing the kit, you should be able to prepare a basic passage study in which observations, interpretations, and applications are clearly distinguished. The kit provides a starting method and reusable worksheets. It does not provide comprehensive training in biblical languages, literary forms, canonical development, doctrine, programmatic classification, diagnostic hermeneutics, or independent capstone exegesis.

How to Use This Kit

- Choose a complete paragraph or short passage rather than an isolated verse.
- Read the passage several times before consulting study notes or commentaries.
- Record what the passage actually supplies before explaining what it means.
- Use the worksheets in order, but return to earlier observations when new evidence requires correction.
- State conclusions only as strongly as the available evidence warrants.

The Governing Sequence

Stage	Controlling question	Result
Meaning first	What does this passage communicate in its context?	A contextual interpretation
Assignment second	To whom does its authority, promise, identity, commission, or obligation directly belong?	A defensible assignment
Application third	How may its truth legitimately shape belief, understanding, worship, conduct, or ministry?	A classified application

Observation supports all three stages. It gathers the words, relationships, setting, structure, and other evidence that interpretation must explain.

1 Scripture Governs the Interpreter

Responsible interpretation begins with submission to what Scripture communicates. A theological system, tradition, teacher, experience, or preferred conclusion may suggest useful questions, but none may replace the evidence of the passage.

An interpreter therefore asks not only, “What do I believe?” but also, “Which words, relationships, contextual features, and related passages establish that conclusion?” This does not eliminate conviction. It disciplines conviction by requiring a traceable relationship between the biblical text and the conclusion.

Foundational Commitments

- ☐ I will read enough surrounding Scripture to follow the developing thought.
- ☐ I will distinguish what the passage states from what I infer.
- ☐ I will allow evidence to correct an inherited or preferred interpretation.
- ☐ I will not make application carry a meaning the passage does not establish.
- ☐ I will acknowledge when the available evidence does not justify certainty.

Evidence and Inference

Category	Description	Example
Observation	Something directly identifiable in the passage	The passage contains a command.
Inference	A conclusion drawn from one or more observations	The command addresses a particular problem implied by the paragraph.
Interpretation	An explanation of what the evidence means together	The writer commands this response because it answers the problem developed in context.

2 Begin With Observation

Observation asks what the passage actually contains before deciding what those features mean. Good observation is selective but not careless. Record details that may affect the passage's developing thought, and postpone conclusions that require additional evidence.

Basic Observation Checklist

- ☐ People, groups, speakers, writers, and recipients
- ☐ Actions and responses
- ☐ Commands, promises, warnings, questions, and explanations
- ☐ Repeated words or ideas
- ☐ Contrasts and comparisons
- ☐ Cause and effect relationships
- ☐ Time, place, and sequence indicators
- ☐ Connecting words such as therefore, for, but, if, because, and so that
- ☐ Stated purpose or conclusion
- ☐ Questions that require more context or evidence

Observation Practice

Select a paragraph of six to fifteen verses. Read it three times. On the first reading, follow the whole thought. On the second, mark repeated words, contrasts, connections, and commands. On the third, identify the features that appear to control the paragraph's meaning.

Passage selected:

Five observations directly supported by the passage:

3 Read the Context

A verse belongs to a developing Scriptural thought. Begin with the immediate passage, then move outward far enough to understand the larger argument, section, and biblical book. After gathering that broader evidence, move inward again and test whether your proposed interpretation fits each level.

Context level	Questions to ask
Verse	What does the sentence actually say? What grammar and connections shape it?
Surrounding passage	How do the nearby verses develop, explain, qualify, or apply the thought?
Larger section	What subject or argument is being developed across the section?
Biblical book	How does the passage serve the book's audience, occasion, purpose, and argument?

Context Record

Immediate subject of the passage:

What comes immediately before and after:

Role of the passage within the larger section or book:

One interpretation that the context rules out or qualifies:

4 Identify the Communication Setting

Meaning is communicated in a setting. Identify the writer or speaker, the direct audience, the occasion, and the apparent purpose from Scriptural evidence. Do not assume that everyone present is directly addressed or that every later reader shares the same identity, circumstances, promise, or obligation.

Element	Evidence to record
Speaker or writer	Who communicates? Does the speaker change? Is another person being quoted?
Direct audience	Who is addressed? How does Scripture identify them?
Occasion	What circumstance, problem, question, event, or need gives rise to the communication?
Purpose	What does the passage appear to explain, command, correct, promise, warn, or accomplish?

Communication Profile

Speaker or writer:

Direct audience:

Occasion established by Scripture:

Purpose evident in the passage:

Evidence supporting the profile:

5 Establish Meaning

Interpretation explains how the observations, context, and communication setting work together. A good interpretation accounts for the passage as a whole, identifies its principal claim or function, and avoids forcing every detail to carry equal weight.

Meaning Statement Procedure

- State the principal subject in one sentence.
- Identify what the passage says about that subject.
- Explain how the major commands, reasons, contrasts, examples, or conclusions support the developing thought.
- Remove claims that depend on information the passage does not establish.
- Test the statement against the surrounding context.

Draft Meaning Statement

In this passage, the writer or speaker communicates that:

The strongest evidence for this interpretation is:

One important inference in my interpretation is:

6 Determine Assignment

Assignment asks where the passage's direct governing authority belongs. This question must follow meaning. It may involve an audience, covenant, promise, commission, identity, obligation, historical situation, or revealed program. Assignment is not decided merely by naming the speaker or writer.

Divine authority and direct assignment are related but not identical questions. All Scripture is inspired and profitable, yet not every command, promise, sign, civil requirement, sacrificial practice, or commission is directly assigned to every reader in every setting.

Assignment Questions

- ☐ Does the passage name or clearly identify its direct audience?
- ☐ What identity, circumstances, promises, responsibilities, or authority does that audience possess?
- ☐ Is the passage descriptive, directly prescriptive, or both?
- ☐ Does later Scripture confirm, qualify, suspend, or distinguish the assignment?
- ☐ Am I assigning the passage because of textual evidence or merely because of the speaker or writer?

Assignment conclusion and supporting evidence:

7 Classify Application

Application follows established meaning and assignment. The purpose of classification is not to avoid application, but to apply Scripture without claiming an authority, promise, identity, or obligation that Scripture assigns elsewhere.

Category	Description
Direct governing	The passage directly governs the reader under the same revealed authority and assignment.
Principled	A legitimate principle extends from the passage without transferring a distinctive program, promise, or obligation.
Historical or doctrinal	The passage teaches what God did, revealed, judged, promised, or accomplished and informs biblical understanding.
Illegitimate programmatic transfer	An application wrongly claims another audience's distinctive promise, identity, commission, sign, or obligation.

Application Record

Proposed application:

Application category:

Why this category fits the passage's meaning and assignment:

A possible illegitimate transfer to avoid:

8 Simplified Passage Study Worksheet

Use this worksheet for a short paragraph or complete unit of thought. It is intentionally introductory: it records the core movement from evidence to application without replacing a full evidence ledger or comprehensive exegetical process.

Passage and boundaries

Principal subject

Important observations

Context that materially affects meaning

Speaker or writer and direct audience

Simplified Passage Study Worksheet Continued

Meaning statement

Assignment conclusion and evidence

Application and category

Question requiring additional evidence

9 Brief Worked Example

Passage: Mark 2:1–12, the healing of the paralytic.

Observation

- Jesus is teaching in a crowded house in Capernaum.
- Four men lower a paralytic through the roof because they cannot reach Jesus through the crowd.
- Jesus first tells the man that his sins are forgiven.
- Some scribes reason that Jesus is blaspheming because only God can forgive sins.
- Jesus knows their reasoning, asks which declaration is easier, and heals the man visibly.
- Jesus states that the healing demonstrates the Son of Man's authority on earth to forgive sins.

Context and meaning

The episode is not merely a general lesson about overcoming obstacles. Its developing conflict centers on Jesus' authority. The visible healing confirms the authority claimed in the less immediately visible declaration of forgiveness. The crowd's amazement concludes the event, but Jesus' identity and authority control its meaning.

Assignment and application

The command to rise, take up the bed, and go home is directly addressed to the healed man. It should not be treated as a universal promise that every faithful reader will receive immediate physical healing. Historically and doctrinally, the passage bears witness to the Son of Man's authority. Principled application may include trusting Christ's authority and refusing to reduce the passage to a motivational slogan.

Evidence boundary

This short study does not by itself establish a complete doctrine of healing, forgiveness, or the Son of Man title. Those subjects require broader biblical investigation. Responsible interpretation distinguishes what the passage clearly establishes from what must be studied elsewhere.

10 Seven Day Practice Plan

Day	Practice	Written result
1	Read the selected passage repeatedly and establish its boundaries.	A one-sentence description of the unit.
2	Record people, actions, commands, contrasts, repetitions, and connections.	Ten direct observations.
3	Study the surrounding passage and larger section.	A context summary.
4	Identify speaker, audience, occasion, and purpose from Scripture.	A communication profile.
5	Draft and test a meaning statement.	A one-paragraph interpretation.
6	Determine assignment and classify a proposed application.	An assignment statement and application category.
7	Review every claim and mark observation, inference, or conclusion.	A corrected final passage study.

Final Review

- ☐ My interpretation accounts for the whole selected passage.
- ☐ I used context rather than an isolated verse.
- ☐ I distinguished direct observations from inference.
- ☐ I established meaning before assignment and application.
- ☐ I did not classify the passage merely because of the speaker or writer.
- ☐ My application preserves the passage's meaning and assignment.
- ☐ I stated no conclusion more strongly than the evidence warrants.

Continue Developing Your Method

This Starter Kit provides an introductory process for a short passage: observe the text, establish context and communication setting, state the meaning, determine assignment, and classify application. Continue using the simplified worksheet until these movements become deliberate habits.

More advanced interpretation requires additional competencies, including grammar and vocabulary, literary form, historical setting, canonical correlation, progressive revelation, doctrine, programmatic authority, evaluation of competing interpretations, counterevidence, diagnostic correction, and integrated exegesis. Those competencies require sustained instruction and guided practice rather than a longer checklist.

About the Biblical Hermeneutics Course

The Zay-Marie Press Biblical Hermeneutics Course is a complete forty-lesson, self-paced, noncredit course for serious independent study and structured teaching. It develops interpretive competence cumulatively through instruction, exercises, checkpoints, diagnostic work, guided exegesis, and a final capstone. The course teaches sound hermeneutical method and does not require adoption of a proprietary interpretive model or proposed chronology.

Course information and previews are available at zaymariepress.com.

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